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Writing 50: Critical Reading and Rhetoric

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From Human to Machine- When “Improving Our Image” in Cosmetic Surgery
Becomes a Curse of Dehumanization

“It all started with a small eyelid surgery, until the pursuit of body perfection started to lose control.” The project I created features a desperate mother who wrote the post on X(Twitter) to warn other parents and adolescents about the danger of cosmetic surgery, after realizing her daughter’s obsession with these procedures had put her in a state of “biological death”. With her daughter Jane Doe’s consent, she shared Jane’s diary entries spanning across years of becoming a “perfect human”, documenting how cosmetic surgery had transformed Jane into a dehumanized “machine,” both physically and psychologically. I chose the name “Jane Doe” because it is a common name that carries the convention of an unidentifiable person, which perfectly shows Jane’s erasure of personal identity. I chose to frame the narrative specifically as an X post because the platform simultaneously serves as a medium for cosmetic surgery advocacy and a space for public warnings. Using compassion as a strategy to achieve its educational purpose, this format is particularly effective in providing readers with both the victim’s and the advocate’s perspectives. By incorporating visual elements, diary text, and user interactions, the post reveals how cosmetic surgery

caused dehumanization in both Jane's physical and psychological state, uncovered commercialization and peer pressure as social causes, and effectively warns audiences against such harm.

The internal dehumanization caused by the surgery is reflected in the diary's visual design, including both sticker decoration and handwriting. Across the pages, Jane shows a trend of using fewer stickers, replacing vibrant colors with desaturated tones, and switching from a cursive font to Times New Roman - showing her transition from prioritizing self-expression to being a perfect, standardized human. The black-and-white color scheme of her final entries also implies that Jane has lost all traces of her original self and reached the state of biological death. To reveal the psychological motivation behind such a shift, I intentionally decorated the full page of the September 18, 2026, diary entry with "eyes" stickers, mimicking Jane's increasingly magnified self-criticism. A large eye dominates the center of the page, with dozens of smaller eyes surrounding the edges, creating an uncomfortable gaze at her own body image.

In addition to sticker decorations, I also used a juxtaposition of photos to contrast human diversity before and after cosmetic surgery. The first photo in the entry shows Jane at her 18th birthday party, surrounded by a group of friends with diverse backgrounds and distinct appearances ("Can you use this character"). As a call-back, I included a second image of Jane at her 28th birthday, but this time all her friends look identical and smile in the same way - They are no longer individual humans but replicas of robots sharing identical body

features(“Can you use this character”). This, again, produces a sense of horror from the creepy “uncanny valley effect” - an unpleasant psychological phenomenon raised by viewing something that stimulates a human but not quite one (Di Natale et al., 2). Together, these visual elements feature Jane’s dehumanization at different stages of her surgical journey, allowing readers to feel the same sense of erosion Jane had experienced both biologically and psychologically.

Jane’s dehumanization could never exist spontaneously. What is the invisible hand that dragged her through this process? To answer the question, I incorporated an allusion and specific textual descriptions that clearly expose the social causes driving teenagers toward cosmetic surgery. In an image from the July 18, 2026 diary entry, Jane sits in a hospital waiting room right in front of a large medical advertisement (“Can you use this character”) - an allusion to the “Big Brother” in George Orwell’s *1984* (Orwell). Unlike the traditional sense of political authority in Orwell’s version, Jane’s “Big Brother” is a commercialized, perfected version of herself. It demonstrates how cosmetic surgeons manipulate individuals’ insecurity as a commercial strategy - a practice that isn’t something fictional but commonly used in our everyday life.

As a supplement of commercialization, I also included a couple of detailed descriptions in the diary to illustrate peer and clinical pressure as social factors. For example, “some girls in my class turned away from me during a conversation” captures a campus bully scene as an early trigger; “Ari told me she is considering a double eyelid surgery” shows teenagers easily

influence one another; and “She kept telling me how cute I am, and just a simple cut on my eyelid would make everything different” reveals how clinics mask the risk of procedures when selling their products. These voices created a monopolized social narrative, exposing teenagers to distorted beauty standards while discouraging them from finding value in diversity. The entry effectively warns parents, teenagers, and medical professionals to reflect on their personal experiences and examine these toxic phenomena in their own lives.

The consequences of Jane’s surgeries, as hinted throughout the diary’s plot and tone, eventually lead to tragic and irreversible outcomes. Several plots in the diary - such as the facial recognition failed to recognize Jane and someone identified her as the wrong person - created a dramatic irony that a surgery intended to make her beautiful actually disguises her identity. What’s more, the tone of the diary entries also undergoes a significant shift. An intimate and reflective tone could be observed in Jane’s first few entries, but her thoughtful voice gradually disappears as the surgical process goes on. By the end of the story, her diaries seem to be full of fragmented sentences, bullet points, and professional language. It also contains a lot of unnatural expressions such as “synthetic organ upgrade” and “complete absence of localized pain” (“Can you rewrite this...”). I intentionally wrote these entries in my own voice and prompted Gemini to rewrite them in a tone of AI-generated style, serving as a validation of Jane’s brain replacement: She started to treat her body as a mechanical system and entirely suppressed her emotions. This ultimately shifted the impact of surgery into an existential tragedy.

To complete the loop of this project's rhetorical choices, I also designed simulated interaction features on X to demonstrate how Linda's post reaches public audiences. The huge number of comments and reposts adds to the popularity of public opinions when it comes to such an important topic. Under the "reply" section, surgeons call for industrial regulation, teenagers cancel their next appointment, parents share their similar experiences, and there is also a press reporting on the issue. With the success of raising public awareness, the post is no longer a personal grief but has transitioned into a public event that changes how people view cosmetic surgery. Equally important is the "what's happening" section, which shows polarized views between the ongoing trend of beauty standards and the warnings. I created this contrast in consideration that social media is a double-edged sword, which can be used to spread out both poisoning cultures and social awareness at the same time. When audiences are reading the post, seeing the number of people who actually suffer from cosmetic surgery actually highlights its urgency, as it protects numerous people from becoming the next victim in this trend.

In reality, the prevalence of cosmetic surgery, influenced by the rigid beauty standard on social media and advanced modern technology, has been a popular procedure for people to improve their appearance more than ever. A 2024 survey from the International Society of Aesthetic Plastic Surgery (ISAPS) shows that more than 15.8 million surgical procedures were performed worldwide, with an overall 40% increase in aesthetic procedures from 2020 to 2024 (Triana et al., 1), and the "extreme version" of this world doesn't seem far away. By

scrolling through social media apps, selecting an image of their favorite celebrity, and telling the surgeon, “I want to look like this”, people can easily replace their facial images and look like anyone they want. However, when we try to erase all our differences in appearance, personalities, and personal values and instead replace them with those standardized products appearing on social media, we are also becoming one of those “products” ourselves? We risk becoming part of the system that never preserves who we are.

I started the post with such a proposed question, and ended with the hope of making the risk visible, just like what I did in Linda’s post.

Appendix 1: Link to my project

Project URL: <https://sophrsr.github.io/linda-chen-diary/>

- The “diary” part: Used Canva for design.
- The “X website” part: Used Claude Code for programming.

References

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